THE CHOIR

Written by

The Panelwise team

Self-written sample screenplay for Panelwise.
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FADE IN:

1 INT. COMMUNITY HALL - NIGHT 1

A tin-roofed hall with plastic chairs in rows. A banner across the stage: REGIONAL CHOIR FESTIVAL - SATURDAY.

Twelve singers in everyday clothes stand on risers. In front of them, conductor MR. NKOSI (60s), bow tie, a pencil for a baton, taps a music stand.

MR. NKOSI
From the top. Sopranos, you are a river, not a car alarm.

The singers laugh. He raises the pencil. They breathe in together.

The hall door bangs open. KEABETSWE (19), wet hair, a backpack, an old guitar case, stands in the doorway. Everyone turns.

KEABETSWE
Is this the choir? I want to join.

MR. NKOSI
The festival is on Saturday. Four days.

KEABETSWE
I learn fast.

ALTO SINGER
(to the woman next to her)
She's late on the first day.

MR. NKOSI
Sing me something. Anything.

Keabetswe puts down the guitar case. She closes her eyes and sings one long clear note. It fills the hall. The tin roof seems to hum.

Nobody speaks.

MR. NKOSI
(quietly)
Second row. Next to Mama Grace.

2 INT. COMMUNITY HALL - EVENING 2

The next rehearsal. Keabetswe stands in the second row beside MAMA GRACE (70s), the oldest singer, who holds her hymn book at arm's length.

The choir sings. Keabetswe is louder than everyone else. Mr. Nkosi stops them with a wave of the pencil.

MR. NKOSI
Keabetswe. A choir is not twelve people singing. It is one person with twelve mouths.

KEABETSWE
I was singing it right.

MAMA GRACE
You were singing it alone, my child.

3 INT. COMMUNITY HALL - KITCHEN - NIGHT 3

A small kitchen with an urn of hot water and a tray of tea cups. Keabetswe sits on the counter. Mama Grace pours two cups.

MAMA GRACE
When I joined this choir I was twenty. I had the loudest voice in the township, and I was very proud of it. The conductor then was a very strict man, Mr. Nkosi's father. He made me stand at the back for a whole year. A whole year at the back, behind the tall men, where nobody could see me. I was so angry. I wanted to leave every week. And then one night, in the middle of a hymn, I stopped hearing myself. I only heard all of us. Like being inside a big warm coat. That was the night I became a singer.
(MORE)

MAMA GRACE (CONT'D)
Before that I was only loud.

Keabetswe looks into her tea.

KEABETSWE
What if I can't hear them?

MAMA GRACE
Then sing softer until you can.

4 INT. REGIONAL FESTIVAL - BACKSTAGE - DAY 4

Crowded and noisy. Other choirs in matching robes warm up in corners. Mr. Nkosi straightens bow ties. Keabetswe peeks through the curtain at a packed hall.

KEABETSWE
There are so many people.

MR. NKOSI
They are not here for you. They are here for the music. That should make you less afraid, not more.

FESTIVAL ANNOUNCER (O.S.)
Please welcome, from the community hall, the Ikageng Singers!

5 INT. REGIONAL FESTIVAL - STAGE - CONTINUOUS 5

The choir walks out under bright lights. Mr. Nkosi raises his pencil.

They sing. Keabetswe begins softly. She glances at Mama Grace. Mama Grace nods.

Keabetswe closes her eyes. Her voice settles into the others like a thread into cloth.

In the audience, people stop fanning themselves with their programmes.

6 INT. REGIONAL FESTIVAL - BACKSTAGE - LATER 6

The choir crowds around a notice board. A typed results sheet. Their name is second.

ALTO SINGER
Second! We have never been second!

MAMA GRACE
(to Keabetswe)
Did you hear them?

KEABETSWE
(smiling)
I didn't hear myself at all.

Mr. Nkosi tucks his pencil behind his ear.

FADE OUT.